

Blockbusters are Back

It's been a merry March for theatre owners as three films crossed the ₹100-crore mark, with *RRR* managing the feat in just six days. But OTTs feel no pressure

BY VIDYA S.

THE INDIAN BOX OFFICE is certainly on the mend after the Omicron wave of coronavirus infections with March witnessing three films—*RRR*, *The Kashmir Files* and *Gangubai Kathiawadi*—enter the ₹100-crore club. But the sheer volume of content being produced and a changed audience mix post-pandemic means that

OTTs are not going anywhere.

Gangubai Kathiawadi, which released on February 25 and stars popular actor Alia Bhatt, earned ₹126 crore in a month, while *The Kashmir Files*, which released on March 11, collected ₹231.28 crore in 18 days, according to the portal Bollywood Hungama. Telugu film *RRR*, which

released on March 25, crossed the mark within six days across the five languages it released in.

Mumbai-based G7 Multiplex and Maratha Mandir Cinema's Executive Director Manoj Desai says he has witnessed houseful shows for all three films, especially in the 6pm-9pm slot. His G7 Multiplex has more than 1,500 seats across six screens and Maratha Mandir Cinema has around 1,000 seats. "In March 2022, we've seen 70-80 per cent increase in footfalls over December 2021. At the time, there was a 50 per cent occupancy cap. Now, 100 per cent seating capacity is allowed. Also, people were scared to come even in December, but now... [they are] more confident."

Trade analyst Sreedhar Pillai says that the three films were bound to bring audiences back, but 5-10 per cent of film-going audiences have permanently migrated to OTTs and are unlikely to return for the smaller films. "It requires a film like *RRR* to draw people to the theatres. It has these two big stars directed by a big director and it's a big action movie."

RRR amassed ₹200 crore domestically across five languages in less than a fortnight of its release, according to Bollywood Hungama. The film had raked in a whopping ₹1,000 crore at the worldwide box office by the first week of April.

"*Gangubai Kathiawadi* also has its own audiences because of director Sanjay Leela Bhansali and actor Alia Bhatt. But the film would have touched ₹100 crore even faster pre-pandemic. In the case of *The Kashmir*



₹1,000

CRORE

RRR's box office collections worldwide till the first week of April